

Passages - How the World Thinks

If we assume too readily that we can see things from others' points of view we end up seeing them from merely a variation of our own.

'An insider is like a fish in a fishbowl,' says Xu Zhiyuan, 'unable to see the exact shape of its surroundings even though those surroundings are perfectly clear to everyone else.'

'we are clearly persuaded more by custom and example than by any certain knowledge'. To travel around the world's philosophies is an opportunity to challenge the beliefs and ways of thinking we take for granted. By gaining greater knowledge of how others think, we can become less certain of the knowledge we think we have, which is always the first step to greater understanding.

We should not be so afraid of over-sweeping claims that we avoid making any generalisations at all.

We can read the classical philosophies of the world and let them live in both two times and two places. If we forget when and where they wrote, we are doomed to misunderstand them. But if we fail to see how what they say applies to here and now, we are doomed to waste or misuse them.

'Originality lies in interpretation'

True, complete awareness is not merely intellectual but actively experiential.

Insight without analysis and critique is just intuition taken on faith. But analysis without insight is empty intellectual game-playing.

'Language adds to reality in that it creates an extra layer on top of it, and this in turn subtracts from reality by obscuring its fullness. "Meanings and judgments are an abstracted part of the original experience, and compared with the actual experiences they are meagre in content,' said Nishida.

Why flies experience time slower